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Topic: Security Sector Accountability and Citizen Trust in Post-EndSARS Nigeria

Theme Alignment: Security Sector Reform & Accountability

Title

Security Sector Accountability and Citizen Trust in Post-EndSARS Nigeria: A Cross-State Analysis of Reform Implementation and Impunity Reduction

Abstract

The EndSARS protests in 2020 showed that Nigeria security sector has a lot of problems with accountability. This led to the Police Act 2020. Promises to reform institutions. We do not know if these reforms have actually improved trust in the security sector across different states in Nigeria. This study looks at the relationship between accountability security outcomes and public trust in law enforcement agencies.

Methodology: I used three datasets for my analysis. The first one is from the Afrobarometer Round 9 survey, which had responses from (n=1,647) citizens. The second one is from the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project, which had records from 2022 to 2025. The third one is from the National Bureau of Statistics which had data on security expenditure across all 36 states and the Federal Capital Territory. I used Python (Pandas/NumPy) to process the data and created a Citizen Security Trust Index. This index measures how people trust institutions. I then used a Multiple Linear Regression model to look at three things that affect trust Security expenditure, incidents per 100,000 people and whether states are following the Police Act 2020.

$$CSTI_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1(Budget)_i + \beta_2(Incidents)_i + \beta_3(Compliance)_i + e_i$$

Results: My Statistical analysis reveals that statutory compliance is the strongest predictor of citizen trust ($\beta_3 = 0.847$, $p < 0.01$), while security incident density shows the expected negative association ($\beta_2 = -0.312$, $p < 0.05$). Also, per-capita budget allocation fails to significantly predict trust outcomes, indicating that spending increases without accountability mechanisms yield minimal gains in public confidence analysis shows, per-capita budget allocation fails to significantly predict trust outcomes, indicating that spending increases without accountability mechanisms yield minimal gains in public confidence following the rules is the predictor of citizen trust. This means that when states follow the rules people are more likely to trust them.

I also found that the number of security incidents has an effect on trust. However just spending money on security does not necessarily increase trust.

Conclusions: Nigerian citizens care more about seeing accountability structures in place than about how much money's being spent on security. States that have functional oversight mechanisms have trust from the public even when we control for security conditions and resource differences. For policymakers who want to protect citizens and end impunity our study provides a strategy: focus on consistently enforcing existing accountability rules rather than just increasing the budget. Nigerias problem is not that it does not have reform laws but that it does not implement these laws consistently across states. Security Sector Accountability and Citizen Trust in Post -EndSARS Nigeria is an issue that requires a careful look at how reforms are implemented. By prioritizing accountability Nigeria can build trust with its citizens. Create a safer and more secure environment. Security Sector Accountability is key, to achieving this goal.